WORKSHOP-IN-A-BOX

Decide what matters most

A 90-minute priority-setting session: from a long list of good ideas to three agreed priorities.

[Organisation] · [Date] · Facilitated by [Name]

SA ANALYTICAL

TODAY'S DECISION QUESTION

[Which three areas will we prioritise in our 2027–2029 grant-making?]

In scope: [budget, period, geography]

Who decides: [this group / the board]

THE NEXT 90 MINUTES

Evidence first, then criteria, then choices

0:00 · 10 min
Open
The question, the output, our agreements

0:10 · 15 min
Evidence
Silent gallery walk of the data

0:25 · 15 min
Criteria
Agree what makes a priority

0:40 · 25 min
Score & map
Score alone, map on Need × Fit

1:05 · 17 min
Commit
Top three, “not now”, owners

1:22 · 8 min
Close
One-page decision record

You leave with three priorities, a “not now” list and an owner for each next step.

HOW WE WILL WORK

Three working agreements

1

Evidence before opinion

We look at what we know before we argue for what we want.

2

Challenge the idea, not the person

Every programme here has champions. Disagreement is welcome.

3

“Not now” is not “never”

Choosing three things means consciously letting others wait.

EXERCISE 1 · 15 MINUTES

What does the evidence tell us?

8 min	**Walk in silence.** Read every card and leave a sticky note on each.
3 min	**At your table:** which one card should most shape our decision?
4 min	**Share:** one sentence per table.

Your sticky notes

Green · confirms what I thought

Yellow · surprised me

Pink · raises a question

EVIDENCE CARD · TEMPLATE

One card, one finding

[Half of our grants go to the region with a third of the need]

[52% vs 33%]

Source: [dataset or report, year]

So what? [Our footprint may not match where need is greatest.]

Good cards

- Hold a single number
- Name their source
- Mix internal data with external need data
- Number 4 to 6 in total

EXERCISE 2 · 15 MINUTES

What should make something a priority for us?

1

Alone · 2 min

Write the two criteria that matter most to you

2

Pairs · 3 min

Agree your top two

4

Fours · 4 min

Agree your top three

All

Room · 6 min

Cluster and converge on 3 to 4 criteria

STARTER CRITERIA · IF THE ROOM STALLS

Four common yardsticks

Need

Scale and severity of the problem; how neglected it is by other funders

Fit

Match to our mission, expertise, networks and added value

Feasibility

Cost, partner capacity, timeframe and risk

Evidence

Proof the approach works, or a credible path to learning

EXERCISE 3 · 25 MINUTES

Score alone, then map together

3 min

Clarify

Questions on the options list. No debate yet.

7 min

Score

Alone, every option, 1 to 5 on each criterion.

5 min

Collate

Average the scores. Which option was hardest to score?

10 min

Map

Place each option on Need × Fit. Discuss the splits.

Your score is your honest view, not a negotiation. 1 = low, 5 = high. Leave a blank if you cannot judge.

THE NEED × FIT MATRIX

High need and strong fit become priorities

	Low fit	High fit
High need	**Partner or advocate** Others better placed	**Prioritise** We are well placed
Low need	**Let go** Weak case on both	**Maintain lightly** Good fit, less need

Reading the map

Need = average need score

Fit = average of fit, feasibility and evidence

“Let go” is the honest start of the “not now” list.

WHERE WE DISAGREE

Disagreement is information

Which 2 or 3 options split the room most?

A high scorer and a low scorer: 60 seconds each.

What would we need to know to settle it?

EXERCISE 4 · 17 MINUTES

We can’t do everything well



Three dots each · 4 minutes

Place them on the options that should be our priorities. You can stack more than one dot on an option.

Then sort · 8 min
Now, Next or Not now

Then own · 5 min
One owner and one dated next step per priority

COMMIT AND LET GO

Now, Next, Not now

Now

Our top three. Each gets an owner and a dated next step.

Next

Revisit at the next planning point or board meeting.

Not now

Consciously paused, so the top three get real attention.

Test: is anything in Now sitting in the “Let go” corner? If so, why?

DECISION RECORD

What we decided today

Priority	Why it ranks here	Owner	Next step	By when
Now 1	[criteria + evidence]	[name]	[action]	[date]
Now 2				
Now 3				

Next: [revisit at next planning point]

Not now: [consciously paused]

Open questions: [to resolve]

CLOSE

One word for how you leave this session

Within 48 hours

Decision record and matrix photo circulated by [name]

By [date]

Open questions answered by their owners

In 3 months

Check in: are the three priorities driving decisions?